The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter

Photograph: Reuters

Sir Keir Starmer told MPs he was “not prepared to walk away”, hours after **Anas Sarwar**, the Scottish Labour leader, urged him to resign. Sir Keir’s communications chief and his top adviser have both stepped down over their boss’s decision to appoint Peter Mandelson as ambassador to America despite Lord Mandelson’s ties to Jeffrey Epstein, a dead sex offender.

American forces captured a tanker that was shipping **Venezuelan oil** in the Indian Ocean. America’s Department of War accused the vessel of breaching the country’s “quarantine” of crude exports from Venezuela. America has relaxed its blockade since toppling Nicolás Maduro, the country’s dictator, but continues to block much of its oil exports. It is the eighth tanker America has seized for carrying Venezuelan oil.

Bangladesh struck a trade deal with **America** setting a tariff of 19% on most exports. The initial proposed levy, of 37%, was lowered to 20% last year. In addition some clothing made with American cotton or fibres will enter America’s market duty-free, said Muhammad Yunus, Bangladesh’s interim leader. The garment sector accounts for the bulk of Bangladesh’s exports.

Alphabet, Google's parent company, will reportedly raise $20bn from a bond sale on Monday, as it seeks to finance its investments in AI. Last week Alphabet said it anticipated up to $185bn in capital expenditure this year, including on data centres. In a rare move for a technology company, Alphabet is also apparently courting banks to buy a 100-year bond.

Israeli strikes killed four people, including a child, in southern **Lebanon**, local officials said. Israel said it was targeting members of Hizbullah. The Shia militia called the attacks a "dangerous escalation". Lebanese authorities say Israeli strikes have killed about 400 people since the ceasefire that followed Israel's war with Hizbullah in 2024.

Eritrea responded to **Ethiopia** after it said that Eritrea was occupying parts of Ethiopia and supporting armed groups in the country, calling the accusations "patently false and fabricated". Ethiopia has been fighting rebels in the Tigray region, which borders Eritrea. Tensions have risen in recent years between the two neighbours; Ethiopia wants to acquire at least one of Eritrea's Red Sea ports.

King Charles III said he felt "profound concern" over allegations involving his brother, Andrew Mountbatten-Windsor, and his ties to **Epstein**. Police are assessing a complaint that the former prince shared confidential government material with the deceased sex offender. Meanwhile Ghislaine Maxwell, Epstein's accomplice serving a 20-year sentence, refused to answer questions from America's House Oversight Committee, invoking her Fifth Amendment right against self-incrimination.

Figure of the day: $660bn. The collective sum Alphabet, Amazon, Meta and Microsoft have pledged to spend on AI in the coming year. Read the full story.

What's so special about Moltbook? Whose face appeared on a restored fresco in Rome? Test your knowledge of the week's events with our pint-sized news quiz.

Photograph: Getty Images

Jimmy Lai is sentenced in Hong Kong

On Monday Jimmy Lai was sentenced to a total of 20 years in prison for collusion with foreign forces and of sedition, crimes under Hong Kong's national-security law. The 78-year-old media mogul has already spent nearly five years behind bars for unauthorised assembly and fraud.

Mr Lai's support for greater freedom in China began after the Tiananmen Square massacre of 1989. Through his newspapers he backed the millions of pro-democracy Hong Kongers who marched first in 2014 and again in 2019. He was among the first people charged under a draconian national-security law that took effect in 2020. The specially selected judges presiding over his case found he was "the mastermind" behind "conspiracies to commit collusion" and sedition.

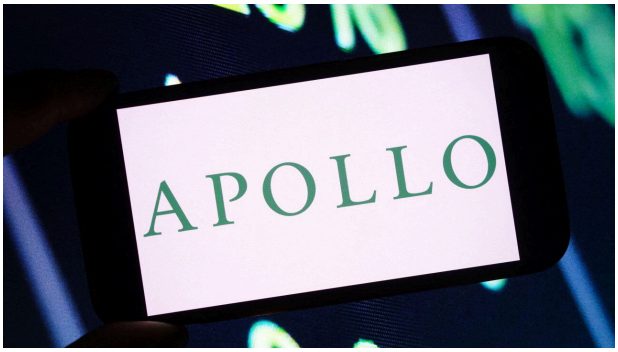
Western governments will probably criticise Monday's sentence. Britain and the European Union have already called Mr Lai's treatment "politically motivated persecution". Authorities in Hong Kong and China, who naturally deny this, will hope they move on quickly. Yet sympathetic Hong Kongers who queued for days to watch the sentencing—some of whom cried at the verdict—may yet honour him as a martyr.

Photograph: Getty Images

Gaza’s phoney peace

In the four months since the end of the war in Gaza several peace-promoting institutions have been established, but they have yet to improve people’s lives. There is a National Committee for the Administration of Gaza, but its members are stuck in Egypt, waiting for Israeli permission to enter the territory. An American military-led co-ordination centre in Israel opened in October to draft plans for the demilitarisation and reconstruction of the strip. A Board of Peace, launched in Davos in January, is scheduled to meet for the first time in Washington on February 19th.

But since the start of the ceasefire Israeli strikes have killed some 500 people in Gaza. The strip remains split between Hamas, which controls the populated areas and refuses to disarm, and the Israeli armed forces, which control the borders and a string of outposts in the territory. Since February 1st a trickle of Gazans, mainly sick and wounded, have been allowed through the Rafah crossing into Egypt. But 2m people are huddled, mostly in tents and ruins, waiting for a breakthrough.



Photograph: Alamy

Apollo’s earnings, oracular implications

Apollo Global Management reported a record quarter on Monday. The private-equity firm brought in nearly $30bn in net inflows in the final three months of 2025, bringing its assets under management to $938bn. That may reassure investors, who have been worried by the private-equity sector’s exposure to private credit following some high-profile bankruptcies last year. Jamie Dimon, the boss of JP Morgan, a bank, warned that more “cockroaches” would appear.

Apollo has rebuffed the doomsayers. It says its focus is now on the “picks and shovels” of artificial intelligence. Firms that make these will succeed even if developers of software run into trouble, Apollo argues. In January it joined a $5.4bn deal backing a company that provides data centres to power Elon Musk’s xAI. It acquired a majority stake in another data-centre firm last year. But if AI proves to be a bubble, it’s not certain that hardware firms will escape the consequences when it bursts.

Photograph: Getty Images

Solving problems while you sleep

When you can't solve a problem, sometimes your dreams can provide the answer, or so it has long been thought. A new study published in *Neuroscience of Consciousness*, a journal, gives support to that idea. Researchers at Northwestern University in Illinois asked 20 "lucid dreamers"—people who report that they are often aware when they're dreaming—to attempt to solve brain-teasers. During the problem-solving process the researchers played an audio cue for each puzzle.

Then they observed the participants' brain activity while they slept. When participants entered rapid-eye-movement sleep, a type associated with dreaming, the researchers replayed the audio cues linked to some of the unsolved puzzles. Upon waking three-quarters of the participants reported dreams that included themes associated with those puzzles. When they tried to solve the puzzles again, they were more than twice as likely to solve puzzles that appeared in their dreams as puzzles that did not. Next, the researchers want to explore what else dreams might be able to do, such as regulating emotions and helping people learn. Something to sleep on.

Illustration: Sandra Navarro

Daily quiz

We will serve you a new question each weekday. On Friday your challenge is to give us all five answers and tell us the theme. Email your responses (and your home city and country) by 1700 GMT on Friday to . We'll pick three winners at random and crown them on Saturday.

Monday: In which Hans Christian Andersen tale does the main character turn out to be a swan?

There is no subject so old that something new cannot be said about it.

Fyodor Dostoyevsky